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Struggle for change in a Nubian community

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ORTHODOX ISLAM

In spite of their avid practice of popular Islam, the Nubians also possessed the common repertoire of orthodox Islamic customs. In addition to the regular Friday mosque service, orthodox observances included the Small Feast, the Large Feast, and the observances of the holy month of Ramadan. During Ramadan, generally a month of reduced economic activity, people fasted from sunrise to sunset, abstaining from food, drink, tobacco, and sexual intercourse. A mosque service was held each night, which most people attended immediately after breaking their daily fast with dates and water. Later in the evening they gathered at the homes of neighbors where special festive foods were served, and, as the water pipe passed from hand to hand, jokes, stories, and experiences were recounted far into the night.

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The Small Feast that followed the month of Ramadan emphasized a happy spirit of friendship and communal solidarity. In the predawn of the first morning of the feast, the women of a Nubian village gathered at the cemetery chanting, "Greetings to you, inhabitants of the grave. May God forgive and rest your souls," and reciting the opening verse of the Koran for each dead relative. Newly cut palm fronds and bowls of water were placed at the ends of recent graves, and water and perfume were sprinkled over them, to appease the ghosts of the dead. Dates, wheat, and sweets were distributed to the children or left for the village poor to collect later. On the same morning, the village

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men gathered in the open air near the cemetery for a predawn prayer led by the imam. At the conclusion of the imam's speech, all the men would rush toward him believing that the first to shake his hand would receive the special blessing of the feast. When each member of the crowd had embraced those near him, tea and sweets were brought by young girls and unmarried youths.

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In another custom of the Nubian Small Feast, all the men of the village, followed by the children dressed in new clothing, would visit each house in their own and neighboring villages where they would be offered special cookies, plates of sweet noodles, popcorn, dates, and small glasses of cinnamon tea. The holiday greeting was "live and see holidays," to which women replied, "You, too, live and see them."

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